English Civil War

During the mid-17th century, England, Scotland and Ireland were sparsely populated. The people had not seen a lot of warfare within their kingdoms. To them, the outbreak of a usual skirmish may have been little more than an inconvenience. But what began as a series of disagreements between King Charles I and the English Parliament developed into an armed struggle. It became a full-scale revolution that took the lives of an estimated 800,000 people.

The English Civil Wars were fueled by conflicts in Scotland and Ireland that had developed in the years preceding. The Bishops' Wars in Scotland and the Ulster Rebellion in Ireland had further increased the tension between Charles I and the Parliament. Although the Civil War destroyed England beyond comprehension, it also devastated the other two kingdoms held by the House of Stuart. For this reason, the English Civil Wars can easily be called the Wars of the Three Stuart Kingdoms.

The first English Civil War was fought between 1642 and 1646, while the second began in 1648 and resulted in a shocking execution of the king. The third war took place between 1649 and 1651 where one side supported the Royals and the other supported the Parliament. The king was forced to flee, which initiated the establishment of the Commonwealth of England. It was a government that was heavily influenced by a political and military expert named Oliver Cromwell. The Parliamentary army's victory over the King forever changed the English constitution. The new roles of Monarchy and Parliament created a considerable shift in politics across the British Isles.

The wars broke out ultimately because there was an attempt to unify the three countries. In 1603, the line of the Tudors came to an end because Queen Elizabeth I died without any heirs. The throne was passed to her cousin King James VI of Scotland who became King James I of England and Ireland. This marked the beginning of power for the Stuarts. For the very first time, the three kingdoms of England, Ireland and Scotland were united under one king. King James I had great difficulty in maintaining peace across these kingdoms because there was a long and bloody history